Teaching Guidelines: Supporting Individuals with PTSD

It is estimated that 70 percent of us have had a traumatic experience in our life, and that 20 percent of those go on to experience post-traumatic stress disorder—the different symptoms that circle around trauma. If we want to be able to help ourselves, each other, and our society, we need to understand the challenge of trauma.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- Be familiar with trauma—what it is and how PTSD symptoms present
- Be able to communicate about and help normalize PTSD in order to reduce shame
- Have good affect tolerance of your own experience

INTRODUCING MINDFULNESS

- Frame mindfulness as a tool in healing and awakening that does not replace therapy and must be carefully employed. Make it clear that therapy may be necessary in order to safely and effectively utilize mindfulness strategies.
- Give hope! We have the capacity to heal trauma.
- Discuss the difference between the tolerance zone (where normal challenges of mindfulness might occur) and the distress zone (where sensations, emotions, and cognitions may feel overwhelming). Help students identify signs of their distress zone.
- Teach and rehearse grounding techniques: Coming back to the anchor of breath or sound, feeling contact points of sitting in the chair or on the cushion and feet on floor, opening eyes and looking around the room, naming objects or sounds.
- Help the student make a plan about how to help themselves if they do get caught in a distress zone. This might include pausing to drink some tea, reading a particular book, listening to certain music, calling a friend, taking a shower, or walking in nature.
- Emphasize compassion, kindness, and self-care from the very beginning and come back to these as often as is needed.

IN THE THICK OF IT: WHEN IT FEELS LIKE TOO MUCH

In clinical research, it has become clear over the years that when trauma and strong fear are present, it is not useful to directly open to them. It is important to first soothe and calm and bring in a sense of safety and love.

- Encourage the student to invoke a safe place or loving presence as a resource anchor before practice. They might also find a photo or talisman to serve as a good resource anchor.
- Explore with the student how to respond to self-loathing—how to name judging and extend kindness. Remind them that the trauma response is an evolutionary part of our wiring and it's not their fault.

- Help them recognize and name cognitive grooves that accompany PTSD—planning, worrying, spinning fear-based stories.
- Practice resourcing, titrating, pendulating, and other mindfulness-based strategies
- When guiding a meditation, use invitational versus directive language—asking themselves permission, giving choice, encouraging the student to go at their own pace.

  For example: You might sense if it's OK to investigate this fear. When you're ready, I invite you to open your eyes and look around.
- It is also helpful to offer other choices, such as how to sit, eyes open or closed, changing posture, or stopping if overwhelmed.